Zyl, a knowledgeable and likeable man respected by the players. Notwithstanding the change, our form remained strangely inconsistent.

One week, we were brilliant, winning the first Test in Nagpur by an innings and six runs, with Hashim scoring an unbeaten 253, Jacques making 173 and Dale taking a sensational 10 wickets in the match. The following week, we were less than brilliant, losing the second Test in Kolkata by an innings and 57 runs, even though Hashim sustained his brilliant form by scoring centuries in each innings and leading a rear-guard action that came within nine balls of saving the Test at the end of the fifth day.

India's win meant the Test series was drawn, and they duly retained the No. 1 position in the official ICC Test rankings.

Our roller-coaster continued into the three-match ODI series. We went down in Jaipur when we were defeated by a single run and were then whipped in Gwalior when Sachin Tendulkar scored an unbeaten 200 in a total of 401, but our fortunes were revived in Ahmedabad when Jacques and I each scored centuries and we claimed the consolation win.

Another year brought another ICC limited-overs tournament, the World Twenty20 in the Caribbean ... and yet another disappointing experience for the Proteas. We lost to India, defeated first Afghanistan and then New Zealand, but then lost to England and needed to beat Pakistan at the Beauséjour Stadium in Gros Islet to qualify for the semifinals.

On another big occasion, we restricted them to 148 in 20 overs and felt well in the game. Then, inexplicably, we struggled to inject any momentum into our run chase and finished 11 runs short. 'We were just not good enough,' Graeme told the media afterwards. 'I guess we have run out of excuses in this situation. It's very, very disappointing.'

We had failed but, true to character, nine days later, we were playing brilliantly. Remaining in the Caribbean, we started a full tour of the West Indies by winning a T20 international series by two matches to nil and then sweeping an extended ODI series, five matches to nil.